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Policy brief: Argument on the implementation of Environmental Chinese Protection policies

Collective leadership in writing is more appealing in terms of nature and collaboration than personalistic leadership, simply because the latter has a significant risk of becoming an irreversible dictatorship but president Xi openly denounces the possibility and argues that personalistic and collective leadership is cyclic and not evolutionary in nature (Shirk, 2018). The system of collective leadership has worked exceptionally well in China: first, because it is a superpower country with its population, second its geographical extent facing many development divides, third having massive five-level governance system, and finally, the Communist Party being the ruling party with more than 80 million members. In a nutshell, no other rule of norm in China works as effectively as the collective leadership. The nature of "collective" ness, with a vast number of organs, reliance on diverse wisdom, accessible grounds for active engagement, and opportunity for criticisms makes it an ideal leadership style avoiding pitfalls. (n.d., The Collective Presidential System with Chinese Characteristics)

However collective leaderships are not fully fault free, it has resulted in poor policy implementation, rampant corruption, and severe internal schisms between party elites, threatening its downfall and the ineffectiveness in addressing climate change and environmental policies. Towards more personalistic leadership President Xi declared the country's aim to be carbon neutral by 2060, 13.5% reduction in nation's energy consumption and 18% cut in carbon dioxide emissions during 2021-25 period. Followed by introduction of dual control strategy requiring a 15% reduction in energy use per unit GDP by 2020. Despite being impossible and chastised by several provinces as an unattainable objective, many provinces pulled through, even if it meant cutting energy, halting factory operations, and cutting residence heating supply in the winter (Johnson & Kennedy, n.d.). It can be inferred that personalistic leadership instills fear and will advance set national targets at any cost and even at the expense of citizen's suffering.

Pollution control statistics a critical driver of cadre evaluation and selection could be easily manipulated, modified, and lied to underhandedly, tweak methods to desired outcomes by local officials, resulting in performance scorecards that are positively biased in their favor. President Xi singlehandedly introduced the vertical management system to reform environmental policies. He mandated a centralized monitoring infrastructure network: where prefectural and county level directly communicated to the provincial level instead to the local government so as to prevent data manipulation. Similarly, Xi deployed ecological survey inspection led by the ecological and environmental protection supervisory group to directly collect local complaints and conduct independent inspections to check the conformity of local government towards central's decree on environmental protections. The formation of these smaller bodies, some of which directly led by president Xi helps provide comprehensive view of the larger policy intervention, define problems adequately and set priorities (Staff, C. B., 2021). Thus, the development of these smaller committees, some of which are directly led by President Xi, aids in providing a comprehensive view of the bigger policy intervention, adequately defining problems, and setting priorities. This is something that collective leadership have difficulty achieving because of its nature: a plethora of ideas and lack of direction.

The essay above argues and provides evidence of how collective leadership failed, but if we were to give collective leadership the benefit of the doubt and believe it functions better, it would be on these three fronts. First, they are in a far better position to advance the synergies of sustainable development goals, mobilize NDCs and energy transition, and build long-term low-carbon development plans by setting short-, medium-, and long-term goals. Second, climate change and environmental challenges are ever-changing issues that can never be handled by a single person's direct leadership but require active collaboration and partnership of both national and international players. Third, better political commitment with enhanced governance and policy implementation with the support of subnational governments and private companies, particularly State-owned Enterprises (SOEs) that collective leadership is better suited to managing with a decentralized form of government, is required for environment protection policy to excel.

Conclusion:

As argued in the essay we cannot clearly state which type of leadership will work great for China both have failed but also worked. What is important to understand is that there are numerous possibilities for high-level policy conflicts between the intersection areas of climate, development, energy transmission, and pollution control, and regardless of leadership style, further exploration of synergies between these areas is required, which provides spaces for dialogues, negotiations, and the ability to solve them.

References

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